

Toddler aggression guide covering impulse control techniques and reading body language cues — Action Checklist

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UNDERSTAND THE BRAIN BEHIND THE BEHAVIOR

- ☐ **Understand the Impulse Control Gap:** Recognize that your toddler lacks the brain hardware to stop themselves on command—this is developmental, not defiant.
- ☐ **Reframe Hitting as a Timing Problem:** Remember that your toddler's prefrontal cortex won't be fully online for another twenty years, so they're not choosing to be difficult.
- ☐ **Become Your Child's External Regulation System:** Act as the calm, external brain your child hasn't built yet by consistently scaffolding their responses until their own system develops.
- ☐ **Trust That Consistent Responses Build Neural Pathways:** Each time you respond calmly to aggression, you're laying down brain wiring that will eventually support your child's own internal regulation.

RECOGNIZE THE WARNING SIGNS EARLY

- ☐ **Identify Your Child's Dominant Trigger:** Pay attention to whether overstimulation, frustration, physical discomfort, or attention-seeking is driving most of your child's aggressive episodes.
- ☐ **Watch for Physical Warning Signs Before Aggression:** Look for early body language cues like hand flapping, freezing, or sudden mood changes that signal dysregulation is building.
- ☐ **Notice Patterns in Timing and Environment:** Track which times of day, settings, or situations tend to trigger your child's aggressive responses so you can prepare in advance.
- ☐ **Shift Your Focus to What Came Before:** Instead of reacting to the hit, ask what warning signs appeared in the minutes leading up to it so you can intervene earlier.

RESPOND WITH SCAFFOLDING INSTEAD OF PUNISHMENT

- ☐ **Pause Before You React:** When aggression happens, take a breath and ask what you're expecting your child to do that their brain physically cannot manage yet.
 - ☐ **Scaffold with Words Instead of Punishment:** Give your child the language for their overwhelming feelings by saying what you see, like 'You're so frustrated the tower fell down.'
 - ☐ **Redirect Before the Amygdala Takes Over:** When you spot the warning signs, step in early and redirect your child to a calming strategy before their alarm system drives the reaction.
 - ☐ **Stay Calm and Predictable in Your Response:** Provide the same calm, consistent scaffolding every time aggression happens so your child learns what a regulated response looks like.
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Companion to the full guide in your Lemon Squeezy library — check off each item as you complete it.